

DE TURNS INTO NIGHT

Cruel satire or misplaced exuberance? Shobhaa De's latest book of paradoxes is a huge let-down.



SUPERSTAR INDIA: FROM INCREDIBLE TO UNSTOPPABLE
by SHOBHAA DE
Penguin
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■ By Dilip Bobb

Globalisation has a lot to answer for. In the West, it's an established tradition for authors to hardsell a new book by appearing on television shows. If he or she has earned the title of "best-selling author" and is also an attractive celebrity, that is a publisher's ultimate fantasy. Jackie Collins always featured on the cover of her steamy novels. So, we now have the Indian answer—superstar author Shobhaa De writing on 'Superstar India' and looking glamorous on the cover. This is brand Shobhaa De, but as the serious non-fiction writer as opposed to the author of erotic novels.

De has been hitting the TV studios, trying to look prim and provocative at the same time. It's a paradox that is eminently suitable considering the book she has just released. *Superstar India* is either cruel satire or horribly misplaced exuberance. If it didn't have the publisher's imprint, one would almost believe it was commissioned by the Ministry of Tourism to celebrate India at 60. Even the subtitle is 'From Incredible to Unstoppable'. De is 60 as well and it was this coincidence that inspired her to embark on this undertaking. How one wishes she hadn't. This is the worst thing she has written, and the contents are so far removed from the title that she could be sued for misrepresentation of facts. If not her, then certainly the publishers who milk the 'best-selling' tag by dreaming up new ways of repackaging authors.

De is the goose that lays Penguin India's golden eggs. Her sultry looks and celebrity status add to marketability but hardly

compensate for exposing the reading public to this literary clunker. De is no social scientist, just an intelligent observer, and there is a world of difference between the two. She has clearly been prodded by her publishers to write a rah-rah book on India but ends up bringing out all the negatives. Never judge a book by its title is an old saw, but it has never been more relevant. She says her sudden love affair with the country is rooted in the belief that India has become a global superpower with one billion 'superIndians'. It's a revelation that even the Bible would find tough to match.

De as cheerleader is okay, De as social scientist is a no-no. One suspects her Eureka moment came when the Sensex was going through the roof, Indian billionaires were crowding the *Forbes* list and all was well with the world. Things have changed since: the markets have tanked, inflation is

racing northwards and many of those 'superIndians' are committing suicide because they can't pay their debts. But why let a few facts stand in the way of a good story? This reads like her personal discovery of India, like Rahul Gandhi's. He stays in circuit houses and eats with impoverished tribals. De flits from one five-star suite to another ("Amitabh Bachchan stayed here, madam") and eats in fancy restaurants while trying to find the real India.

The result is the Book of Paradoxes. She mocks her own title by focusing on the negatives about India: rituals, hypocrisy, sexual inadequacies ("A booming economy does not produce instant erections"), prejudices, corrupt politicians, communalism. It's all here but what it's doing wrapped up in a book called *Superstar India* is impossible to figure. Her love of Hinglish is irritating: words like *halaat* and *ajeeb* grate like chalk on blackboard, as does her usage of hip slang.

So what's the basis of her thesis? She puts hope in clichés: a young population, NRIs returning to India, confident businessmen, aggressive cricketers, number of billionaires and, wonder of wonders, the rise of Mayawati. The bulk of the book, however, is a tirade against the evils of Indian society. At the end, she concludes that India is ripe for a makeover—in her words, a 'Rakhi Sawant moment'. Clearly, De has been watching too many Bollywood movies and this is her answer to *Chak De! India*. There are detours to foreign locales, just so we know her jet-set lifestyle is intact. Admittedly, she does say that she would write on India 'warts and all'. Except that by the end, the warts are all one sees. Indeed, the contradictions are much too glaring to ignore. Her big hope is the young, but in another context she labels them as being 'bland, featureless, wobbly and uncertain', which pretty much describes this book. ■



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